



WEEK THREE · MODULE ONE

Discretion, Trust and Presence

The posture that makes you irreplaceable, and the one lapse that ends everything

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

Maison Amarine · Confidential · For the use of our mentees only

CONTENTS

Contents

I	What trust actually is, and what it is not
II	Discretion is a system, not a virtue
III	The classification of information
IV	The NDA, and what it does not cover
V	Devices, records, and the written trail
VI	Social media: the fastest ending there is
VII	The grey zones
VIII	Presence: being there without weighing
IX	How trust breaks, and whether it can be rebuilt
.	Glossary
.	Self-assessment
.	Further study

HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This is the most important week of the programme. Everything else can be learned later. This cannot be recovered once it is lost.

Read it slowly. Almost every rule in it exists because someone was dismissed, and told nothing.

The deliverable this week is a code of conduct that you will sign. Read the module with that in mind.

CHAPTER I

What trust actually is

And why competence has almost nothing to do with it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Define trust as it is understood in a private household.

Understand why it is asymmetric, and what that means for you.

Accept the timeline: slow to build, instant to lose.

1.1 · A definition

DEFINITION

Trust, in private service. The settled expectation that nothing you learn, see, or are given access to will ever be used, repeated, recorded, or turned to advantage, at any point, for the rest of your life.

Note the phrase **for the rest of your life**. Not for the duration of your employment. Not until the NDA expires. Trust in this world has no end date, and the people who understand that are the people who are still working in it at fifty.

1.2 · The asymmetry

Trust here is not mutual, and it is important that you accept this without resentment. **They are not required to trust you. You are required to be trustworthy.** The relationship is unequal by design: they are handing you their children, their home, their movements, their weaknesses and their money, and you are handing them a CV.

That asymmetry is uncomfortable, and it is also the reason the work is paid what it is paid. If it were symmetrical, anyone could do it.

1.3 · The timeline

Phase	What is really happening
Months 1 to 3	You are being watched, constantly and quietly, by the staff more than by the family. Nothing you say is neutral. Nothing you are told is complete.

Phase	What is really happening
Months 3 to 12	Small tests. A confidence that does not matter, to see whether it travels. A minor discrepancy in an expense, to see whether you flag it. An invitation to gossip, to see whether you take it.
Year 2	If you have held, you begin to be told things before you need to know them. This is the moment the work becomes possible, and it is why the two-year rule exists.
Any moment, forever	One lapse, and every one of the above is erased. Not damaged. Erased.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Trust has no expiry date. Not the end of the contract, not the end of the NDA.

The relationship is asymmetric by design. Accept it without resentment.

Two years to build. One afternoon to lose. There is no proportionality here, and there never will be.

CHAPTER II

Discretion is a system

Not a virtue, and not silence

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand why "keeping secrets" is the wrong model.

Apply the three questions before speaking, every time.

2.1 · The misunderstanding that ruins careful people

Almost everyone believes discretion means keeping secrets. It does not, and that misunderstanding is why so many honest, careful people fail at this. Anyone can keep a secret: a secret announces itself as one, and you simply hold it.

The craft is in the thousand pieces of information that are not secrets at all. A departure date. A supplier's name. A child's school. A mood at breakfast. The fact that the office telephoned twice this morning. Each is trivial. Assembled by someone patient, they describe a family completely, and they describe their vulnerabilities exactly.

DEFINITION

Information hygiene. The disciplined management of the flow of information around a principal: what is recorded, where, in what channel, to whom, and for how long. It is a system, practised identically on quiet days and on difficult ones.

2.2 · The three questions

Before any sentence about the family leaves your mouth, in any room, to anyone:

- Does this person need this in order to do their work?
- Would the principal be comfortable hearing me say this, in this room, to this person?
- If this sentence were repeated to a stranger, could it be traced back to the house?

If any answer is uncertain, the sentence is not said. There has never been a penalty, in the history of this profession, for having said less.

CHAPTER III

The classification of information

Five classes, and the channel each one travels in

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Classify any piece of information instantly.

Know which channel each class may travel in, and which it may never.

Class	Examples, and the rule
Public	What the family has themselves made public. Even here: you do not comment, confirm, amplify or correct. Silence costs nothing, and it is the only posture that never backfires.
Household	Routines, suppliers, staff, standards, provisions. Shared inside the house on a need-to-know basis, and never outside it. Not with your partner. Not with your mother. They will not understand why, and you will tell them nothing anyway.
Movement	Where the family is, when, for how long, with whom, and when a residence stands empty. This is security information. It travels only in the channels the house has designated, never in reply to a friendly question, and never "just to a friend".
Personal	Health, relationships, finances, the children, conflicts. It does not leave you. It does not enter a message. It is not discussed with colleagues who already know, because "they already know" is how every leak in history has begun.
Legal or incident	Anything that may become a matter for lawyers, police or press. It goes to the office immediately, in writing, and you make no decisions of your own, not even small ones, not even helpful ones.

THE TEST THAT CATCHES ALMOST EVERYTHING

Would this sentence be harmless if the person hearing it were being paid to collect it?

Because sometimes they are. And you will never be able to tell which ones.

CHAPTER IV

The NDA

What it is, what it binds, and what it does not cover

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read an NDA correctly, and know what to do when you do not understand a clause.

Understand why the NDA is the floor and not the standard.

4.1 · What you will sign

A non-disclosure agreement, before or upon entering the household. It binds you to silence about everything you see, hear and learn. Frequently it survives the end of your employment, sometimes permanently. Frequently it covers your family and anyone you might tell.

- **Read it.** Actually read it, and not in the room, and not in five minutes with someone watching.
- **If you do not understand a clause, say so, and take advice.** Asking for two days to review a contract is entirely normal, and a serious house will respect it. A house that pressures you to sign immediately has told you something important about itself.
- **Never sign something you cannot honour.** If it forbids something you cannot in conscience accept, that is a fact worth knowing before you begin rather than after.
- **Keep a copy.** You will need to know, in ten years, exactly what you agreed to.

4.2 · What it does not cover, and why that matters more

An NDA cannot compel you to conceal a crime, to lie to an investigator, or to participate in something unlawful. If you are ever asked to do any of those things, the document in your drawer does not protect you, and it does not protect them either. **Take advice, immediately, from someone outside the household.**

4.3 · The deeper point

THE FLOOR, NOT THE STANDARD

The professionals worth hiring behave as though an NDA existed even where none was signed. If your discretion depends on a document, it is not discretion. It is compliance, and compliance ends the day the document does.

CHAPTER V

Devices, records, and the written trail

Everything you write will be read by someone you did not intend

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Operate your telephone and your messages as a professional.

Keep the record that protects you, and never the record that endangers them.

- **Assume everything you write will one day be read by the principal, by a lawyer, or by a journalist.** This is not paranoia. It is simply what happens, and writing accordingly costs nothing.
- **Use the channel the house designates, and only that one.** Not your personal messaging app because it is easier.
- **Never photograph anything.** Not the view, not the aircraft, not the table you laid beautifully. The photograph that ends a career is almost never malicious. It is proud.
- **Lock your devices. Enable remote wipe.** A lost telephone containing a principal's diary is a security incident and must be reported as one, immediately, whatever it costs you in embarrassment. The embarrassment lasts an hour. The alternative lasts forever.
- **Never store household information in a personal cloud, a personal note-taking app, or a shared family computer.**
- **Delete nothing in a hurry.** If something has gone wrong, deleting looks exactly like concealing, and it is indistinguishable from it afterwards.

The record that protects you

Keep your own log: dated, factual, unemotional. Instructions received. Decisions taken. Sums approved, and by whom. Not to build a case, and not out of suspicion, but because one day you will need to remember precisely what was said, and **memory is not evidence**.

That log contains facts and dates. It never contains opinions, judgements, or anything about the family's private life. If you would not want it read aloud, it does not belong in it.

CHAPTER VI

Social media

The fastest ending in this profession

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Apply the four absolute rules.

Understand why the innocent version is the one that ends careers.

- **No photograph taken inside a residence, a car, an aircraft, or a yacht.** None. Ever. Not for your mother, not in a private message, not "just to show someone".
- **No location.** No "I can't say where I am, but 📍". That is a boast, and a boast is a breach: it announces both that you know something and that you enjoy holding it.
- **No public account from which an employer can be deduced.** Consultants look. The family's security team looks. Occasionally, so does a journalist.
- **No comment, ever, on anything to do with wealth, service, or your work,** however general it seems. The people who read carefully are exactly the people you do not want reading.

THE CASE THAT SHOULD FRIGHTEN YOU

A chalet manager photographed a laid table at night. Empty. No people, no faces, no names. Only the mountains through the window.

Three days later a journalist identified the chalet from the view, and the family's presence in the valley, which had been kept quiet, was published.

She had done nothing malicious, and she was entirely correct about that. It changed nothing. A photograph does not need to contain a person in order to reveal one.

CHAPTER VII

The grey zones

The moments that decide a career, and which never look like it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Prepare your response to each of the six situations, in advance and in calm.

Escalate correctly rather than deciding alone.

The situation	What you do
A journalist calls.	"I am not able to help with that." End the call courteously and add nothing. Do not confirm. Do not deny, because a denial is information. Do not say "I will have to check", which confirms that you could. Then tell the house immediately: the number, the time, the exact question.
A friend asks what it is like.	Speak of the work, never of the people. "It is demanding, and I love it" is a complete answer, and repeating it word for word every time is a discipline, not a failure of imagination.
A colleague criticises the family in front of you.	Do not join. Do not report it gleefully. Do not remember it fondly. Simply do not participate, and let the silence be understood. You will not be popular for ten minutes, and you will be employed for ten years.
The principal confides something painful.	Receive it. Do not react. Do not refer to it again unless they do. Being trusted is not an invitation to intimacy, and the following morning you are exactly as you were the day before.
A divorce, an illness, a legal matter.	You are the judge of nothing, and you are also the accomplice of nothing. Where lawyers may be involved, take advice, and never decide alone. Never carry a message between two people in conflict.
You are asked to say something untrue.	However small. However lightly it is asked. "I would rather not, I am sure you understand." Then escalate the same day. The smallness is the danger: a large improper request announces itself, and a small one establishes a precedent that the next request will cite.

CHAPTER VIII

Presence

Being there without weighing

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Manage your physical and emotional presence in a house.

Understand why availability and invisibility are not in conflict.

8.1 · The paradox

You must be completely available and completely unobtrusive at the same time. Most people can do one. The whole profession lives in the ability to do both.

- **Enter quietly, and pause.** Never cross a room while someone is speaking.
- **Stand still.** Fidgeting, adjusting, checking: all of it reads as anxiety, and anxiety in staff makes a family anxious.
- **Do not fill silences.** The person who is comfortable in a silence is the person who is trusted in it.
- **Never appear rushed, even when you are.** Speed is a private matter. Visible haste tells the family that something is wrong, which is the one message you are paid to prevent.
- **Leave before you are noticed leaving.** The exit is part of the service, and almost nobody thinks about it.

8.2 · The emotional dimension, which nobody warns you about

You will be present at illnesses, at griefs, at arguments, at the ordinary Tuesday evenings of a family's life. You will care about them, genuinely, because you are a human being and they are in front of you every day.

And you will hold that care at exactly the right distance, permanently, and nobody will ever thank you for it, and no one outside this profession will understand what it costs. **That is the work. That is the actual work,** and everything else, the tables and the flights and the vendors, is logistics.

CHAPTER IX

How trust breaks

And whether it can ever be rebuilt

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the four ways it breaks.

Know, honestly, which of them can be recovered from.

How it breaks

Can it be rebuilt?

The leak. Something got out. However innocently, however indirectly, however far from your intention.

No. Not ever, and not partially. The house cannot un-know that information travels through you.

The concealment. An error, softened, delayed, or managed. Not the error itself, ever: the management of it.

Almost never. Because they must now re-read everything you have ever told them.

The drift. Familiarity. The slow becoming of a friend, a confidante, a member of the family.

It cannot be reversed, only prevented. And it usually ends with your departure, generously arranged, and without explanation.

The small dishonesty. An expense rounded up. A message you said you passed on. A morning you said you were somewhere you were not.

No. And this is the cruellest one, because it is always trivial, and it is always fatal, and the person who does it never believes it will be discovered.

THE SENTENCE TO KEEP

There is no proportionality in this. A tiny breach and an enormous one produce the same outcome, because both prove the same thing: that it is possible.

Once they know it is possible, they cannot un-know it, and they will never be at ease in front of you again.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Discretion is a system, not a silence, and it is practised on quiet days.

The NDA is the floor. Your standard is what you do where no document reaches.

Movement information is security information. Always.

Trust breaks by leak, by concealment, by drift, or by a small dishonesty. None of the four is recoverable.

Glossary of the module

Information hygiene · The disciplined management of what is recorded, said, sent and kept about a principal.

Movement information · Where the family is and when a residence is empty. Always treated as security information.

NDA · Non-disclosure agreement. The floor of discretion, never its standard.

The drift · The slow slide from trusted professional into friend or confidante. Prevented, never reversed.

The record · Your dated, factual, unemotional log of instructions and decisions. Facts only, never opinions.

Escalation · Passing a matter to the office, the same day, in writing, without drama and without deciding alone.

Presence · Complete availability and complete unobtrusiveness, held at once.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing. This is the week where the honest answers matter most.

1. Why is "keeping secrets" the wrong model for discretion? Answer in terms of what actually leaks.
2. Write the three questions from Chapter II from memory.
3. Classify each of these: the chef's name; the date the family leaves for Sardinia; the principal's medication; a threatening letter received at the house; a photograph the family posted themselves.
4. A clause in your NDA is unclear to you. What do you do, and what do you refuse to do?
5. Why is the NDA the floor rather than the standard?
6. A journalist calls and says he already has the story. Give your exact words, and explain why "I will have to check" is catastrophic.
7. You have made an error. Explain, in one paragraph, why concealing it is worse than the error, and why it cannot be recovered from.
8. What is the drift, and give three early symptoms of it in yourself.
9. Why does a small dishonesty destroy trust as completely as a large one?
10. What, honestly, would you find hardest about this week? Write it down. We will begin there.

Further study

- **Audit your own social media this week**, from the first post to the last. Not for what is damaging; for what could be assembled. You will be surprised, and you should be.
 - **Read one serious article on OSINT** (open-source intelligence): how a life is reconstructed from fragments that were each harmless on their own. It will change how you think about a departure date forever.
 - **Practise the sentence "I am not able to help with that" out loud**, twenty times, until it is boring and unembarrassed.
 - **Notice, this week, every time you were about to say something you did not need to say.** Count them. That number is your starting point.
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